

DOCUMENT METADATA

Document Name:

Press Release on Psychedelics - 01-05-23.pdf

Title:

1-5-24: To improve care for Veterans, VA to fund studies on new therapies for treating mental health conditions

Topic:

Psychedelics

Document Type:

Press Releases

Created:

2024-04-01 by Bartlinski, David

Modified:

2024-07-19 by Richman, Michael (VACO)



Talk to the Veterans Crisis Line now

[VA.gov](#)

[Locations](#)

[Business](#)

[VA Careers](#)

[Contact Us](#)

VA | News

[News](#) ▾

[Resources](#) ▾

[VA Podcast Network](#)

[VA Press Room](#)



[Home](#) / [Press Room](#)

To improve care for Veterans, VA to fund studies on new therapies for treating mental health conditions

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

January 5, 2024 1:00 pm

New research would determine the benefit of psychedelics for treating

PTSD and depression in Veterans

WASHINGTON — Today, the Department of Veterans Affairs issued a request for applications (RFA) for proposals from its network of VA researchers (in collaboration with academic institutions) to study the use of certain psychedelic compounds in treating posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and depression.

Through this new research opportunity, VA intends to gather definitive scientific evidence on the potential efficacy and safety of psychedelic compounds such as Methylenedioxymethamphetamine (MDMA) and psilocybin when used in conjunction with psychotherapy to treat Veterans with PTSD and depression. This is the first time since the 1960s that VA is funding research on such compounds.

“Our nation’s Veterans deserve the very best care, and VA is constantly supporting innovations to deliver that,” said **Secretary of Veterans Affairs Denis McDonough**. “This is an important step to explore the efficacy of a potential new set of promising treatments that could improve the health and quality of life for Veterans.”

“[Veterans and VA researchers have told us](#) about the potential promise of psychedelics to treat mental health conditions for some time,” said **VA’s Under Secretary for Health Dr. Shereef Elnahal**. “Now is our chance to study this potential method of treating Veterans with PTSD and major depression across the country.”

VA and the Biden-Harris Administration are committed to exploring all avenues that promote the health of our

nation's Veterans. As with all other VA studies, research conducted on psychedelic compounds will be completed under stringent safety protocols. While these compounds are controlled substances, tightly restricted under federal law, research on these compounds may be conducted with appropriate regulatory approvals, including those from the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) and Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA). The FDA granted breakthrough therapy status for MDMA for treating PTSD and psilocybin for treating depression in (2018 and 2019, respectively) based on promising preliminary research evidence.

In September, more than 75 VA and other federal clinicians, scientists and policy makers gathered in Denver to assess the state of existing scientific evidence regarding psychedelic-assisted therapies. This meeting's working groups provided advice to VA leadership, including the recommendation for VA to begin funding its own studies into these compounds. This guidance was based on [previously published studies](#) that have found promising results but included few or no Veterans. For example, [researchers at Johns Hopkins have shown](#) that psilocybin therapy, given with supportive therapy, can ease symptoms of depression for up to 12 months. Additionally, 86% of participants in a [recent peer-reviewed study](#) achieved a "clinically meaningful benefit" from using MDMA to treat PTSD.

VA researchers have already conducted a limited number of small studies on psychedelics in VA facilities using non-VA funding. This new RFA will permit the important next step of directly assessing

effectiveness and safety of using MDMA and psilocybin-augmented psychotherapy in Veterans.

Expanding research on psychedelics to address Veteran mental health is also in line with calls from Veterans Service Organizations such as the [American Legion](#) and [Disabled American Veterans](#), as well as [mental health provider groups](#). The National Defense Authorization Act for fiscal year 2024 also authorized the study of psychedelics within military populations by the Department of Defense. With this new announcement, VA will join the National Institutes of Health in supporting research that will yield insights for treating PTSD and depression.

Psychedelic drugs are a class of substances that alter consciousness or awareness and may be organically or synthetically produced. VA does not recommend psychedelics for use as part of a self-treatment program.

If you're a Veteran struggling with a mental health or substance-use disorder, the VA can help. Find out about available resources [here](#).

###



Reporters and media outlets with questions or comments should contact the Office of Media Relations at vapublicaffairs@va.gov



Veterans with questions about their health care and benefits (including GI Bill). Questions, updates and documents can be submitted online.

[Contact us online through Ask VA](#)



Veterans can also use our chatbot to get information about VA benefits and services. The chatbot won't connect you with a person, but it can show you where to go on VA.gov to find answers to some common questions.

[Learn about our chatbot and ask a question](#)



[Subscribe today](#) to receive these news releases in your inbox.

Topics

[Benefits](#) [Mental Health](#)

[Secretary McDonough](#)

Link Disclaimer

This page includes links to other websites outside our control and jurisdiction. VA is not responsible for the privacy practices or the content of non-VA Web sites. We encourage you to review the privacy policy or terms and conditions of those sites to fully understand what information is collected and how it is used.

LET OTHERS KNOW ABOUT THIS



More from the Press Room

NEWS RELEASES
JANUARY 11, 2024

**More than
31,000
Veterans
sign up for
new VA life**

NEWS RELEASES
DECEMBER 15, 2023

**VA
announces
hundreds of
millions in
grant**

NEWS RELEASES
DECEMBER 12, 2023

**VA has
screened 5
million
Veterans for
toxic**

insurance program in first year

The Department of Veterans Affairs' new guaranteed-acceptance insurance program, VAlife has issued more than \$950 million in coverage to 31,400 Veterans in its first year.

funding to help homeless Veterans after new data shows an uptick in homelessness

VA to provide millions in grant funding to help homeless Veterans following an uptick in homelessness.

exposures, paving the way for early detection and treatment of health conditions

the Department of Veterans Affairs announced that it has screened 5 million Veterans for toxic exposures – a critical step to detecting, understanding, and treating potentially life-threatening health conditions.



U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs
810 Vermont Ave., NW
Washington, DC 20420
[1-800-698-2411](tel:1-800-698-2411)

VA News

An official website of the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

VA.gov	Whistleblower	Privacy policy
ChooseVA	Protection	FOIA requests
VA Forms	Office of the Inspector	Disclaimers
VA Publications	General	Open data
About VA	VA plans, budget,	Vulnerability disclosure
VA mobile apps	finances, and	policy
Accessibility at VA	performance	Copyright policy
No FEAR Act data	Agency Financial Report	

Looking for U.S. government information and services? Visit [USA.gov](#)